
How the six laboratories work

ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIVE PLAY

These are original engine-assisted study continuations from this course's positions. They are not historical master games and no invented players or tournament results are assigned. The continuations reach roughly move twenty and stop for further practice.

THINK BEFORE REVEALING

At each checkpoint, name the opponent's threat, compare two candidates and calculate a forcing reply. Use a board to replay the sequence. The engine comparison supplies concrete evidence, while the opening explanation supplies a plan.

MORE THAN ONE GOOD MOVE

Close engine scores do not establish a unique answer. The finite search can prefer a different move when run longer. Accept another candidate if you can support it with a sound variation and a coherent explanation.

PRACTICE FROM BOTH SIDES

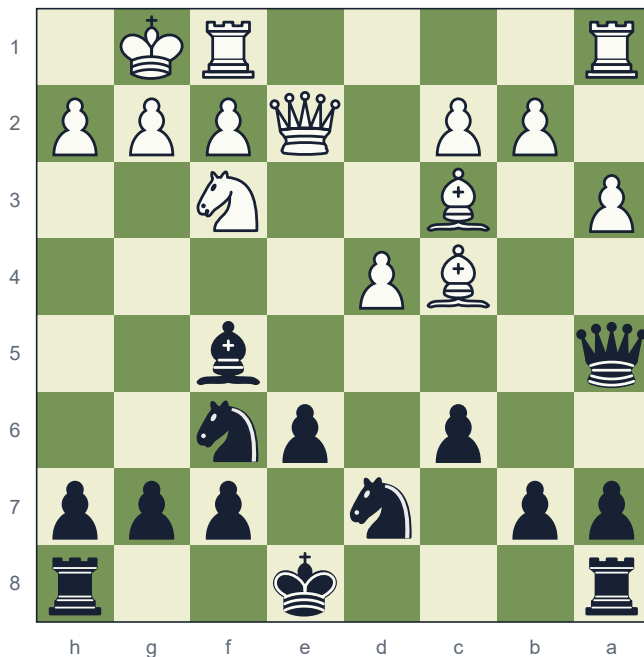
Play each starting position twice, switching colors. Record the first decision you could not explain and compare it with the branch lesson after the game.

SC-LAB-01 / The classical development route

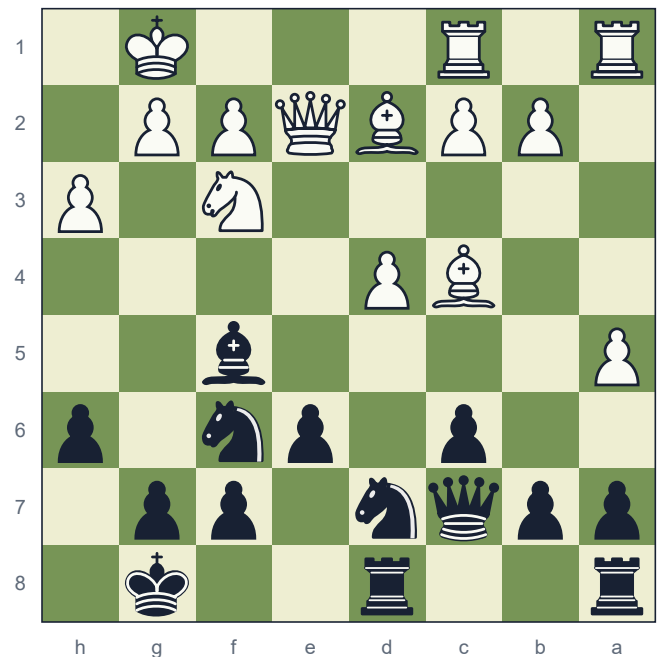


SC-LAB-01 / play and explain 1

11... Qd8 12. a4 O-O 13. a5 Qc7 14. h3 h6 15. Bd2 Rfd8 16. Rfc1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... QD8

Places the queen on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... QC7

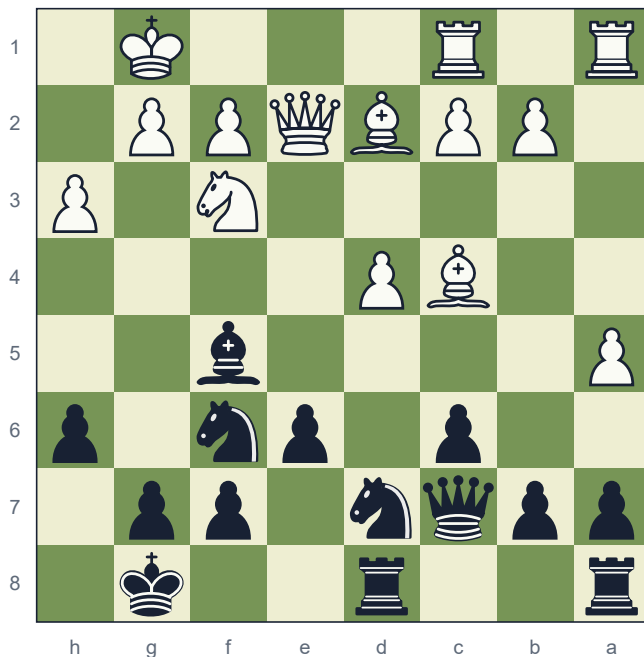
Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

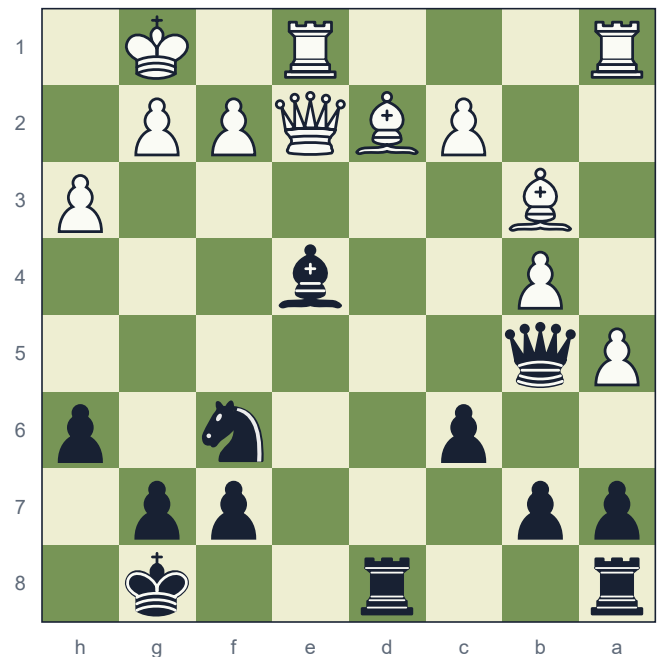
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-01 / play and explain 2

16... Be4 17. b4 e5 18. Nxe5 Nxe5 19. dxe5 Qxe5 20. Bb3 Qb5 21. Re1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... BE4

Places the bishop on e4, attacking knight on f3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

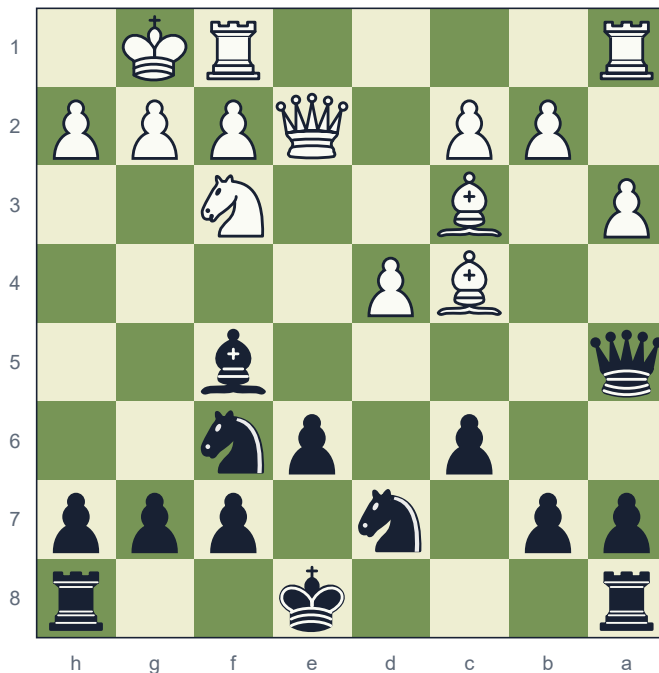
18... NXE5

The knight captures a knight on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qd8 and Qc7. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QD8

11... Qd8 12. b4 Be4 13. a4 O-O 14. a5 b5 15. Bd3 Search estimate: -0.39 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QC7

11... Qc7 12. Nh4 Bg6 13. a4 a5 14. Rfd1 Nd5 15. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.42 from Black's perspective.

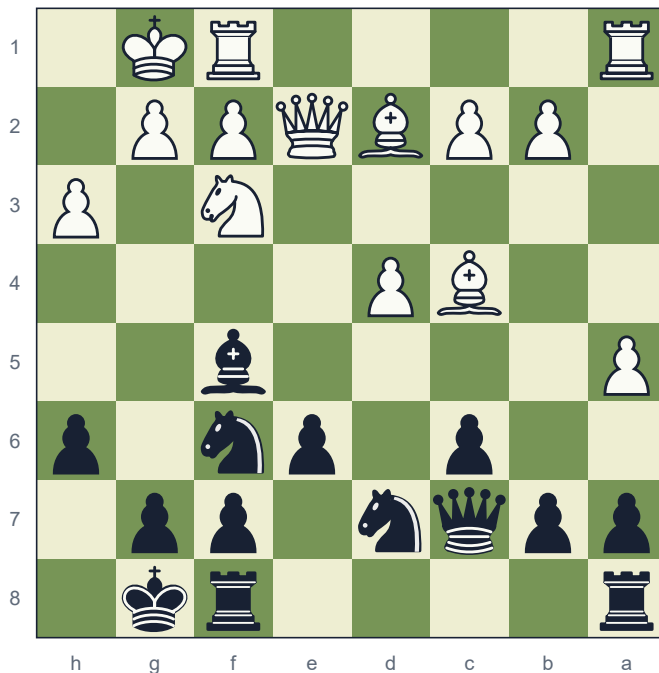
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rfd8 and Rac8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RFD8

15... Rfd8 16. Rfc1 Search estimate: -0.48 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RAC8

15... Rac8 16. Rfc1 c5 17. a6 b6 18. Bb5 Rfd8 19. dxc5 Search estimate: -0.48 from Black's perspective.

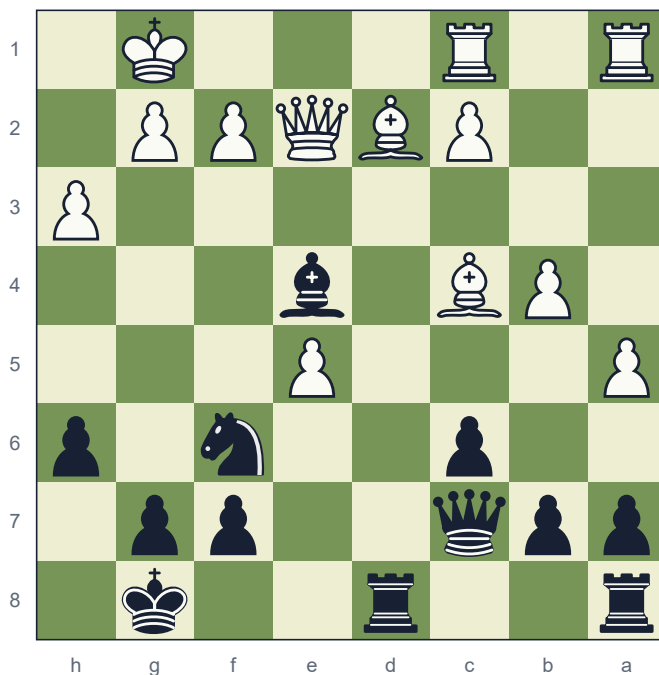
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qxe5 and Rxd2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QXE5

19... Qxe5 Search estimate: -0.37 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RXD2

19... Rxd2 20. Qxd2 Qxe5 21. Re1 Qb2 22. Rad1 Qxc2 23. Qxc2 Search estimate: -3.66 from Black's perspective.

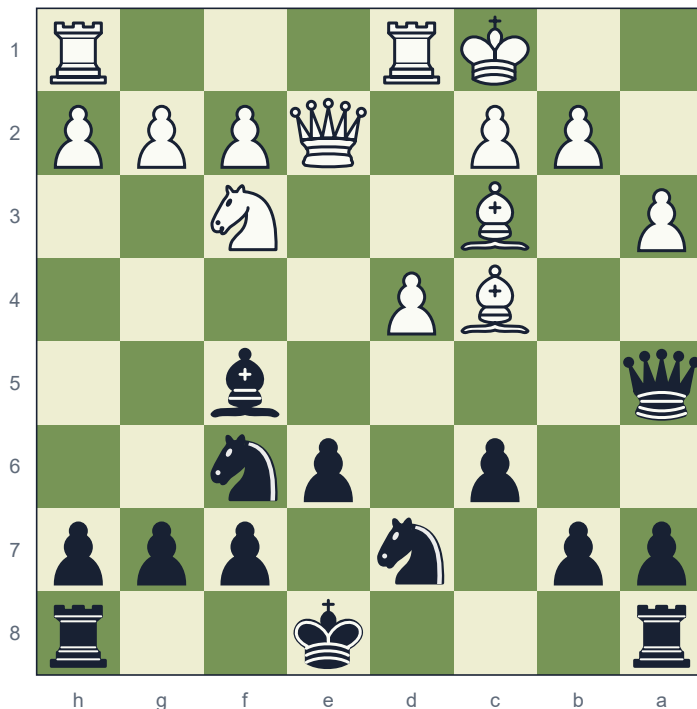
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The queen captures a pawn on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / White uses Qe2 and long castling



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Qe2 prepares long castling and increases central pressure. ...Bb4 develops with a concrete relation to the c3 knight rather than immediately making another pawn move.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

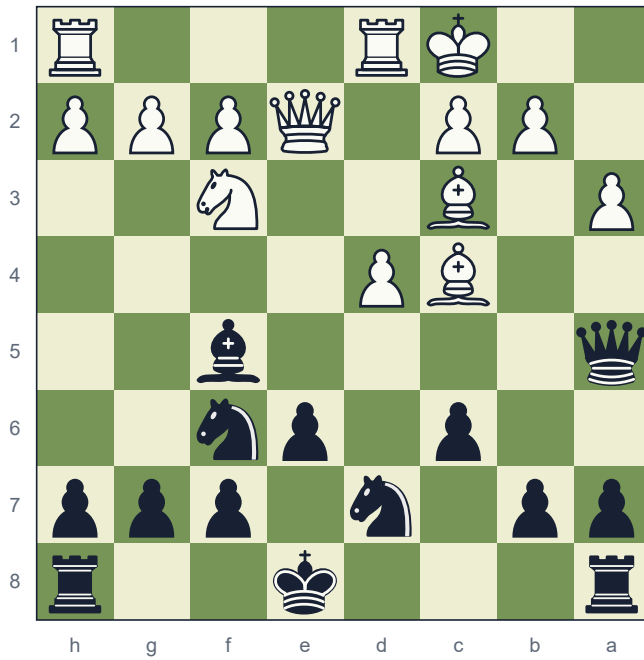
White can play O-O-O and advance the kingside pawns. Opening the center while your own king remains on e8 can be dangerous. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

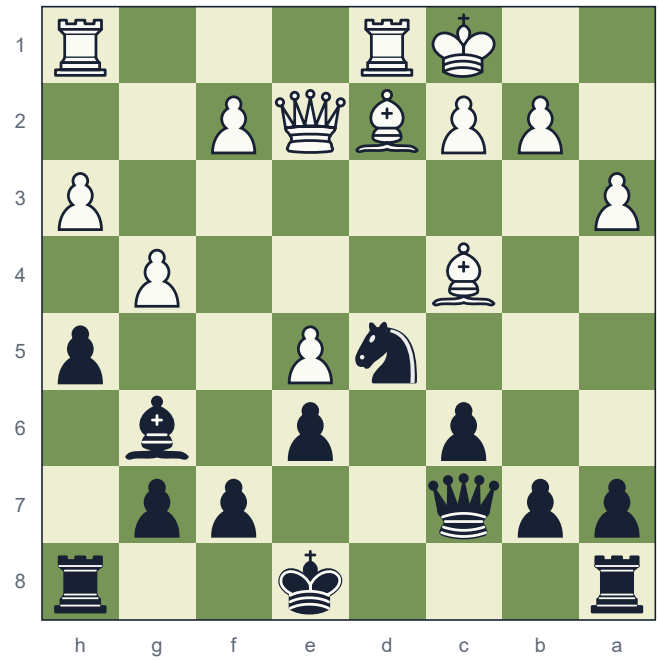
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-02 / play and explain 1

11... Qc7 12. Ne5 Nd5 13. g4 Nxe5 14. dxe5 Bg6 15. Bd2 h5 16. h3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... Qc7

Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... NXE5

The knight captures a knight on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

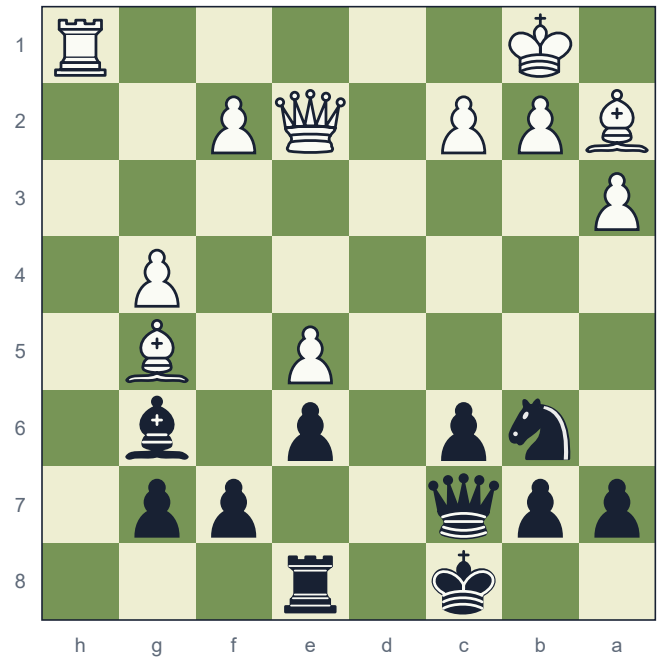
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-02 / play and explain 2

16... hxg4 17. hxg4 Rxh1 18. Rxh1 O-O-O 19. Bg5 Re8 20. Kb1 Nb6 21. Ba2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... HXG4

The pawn captures a pawn on g4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

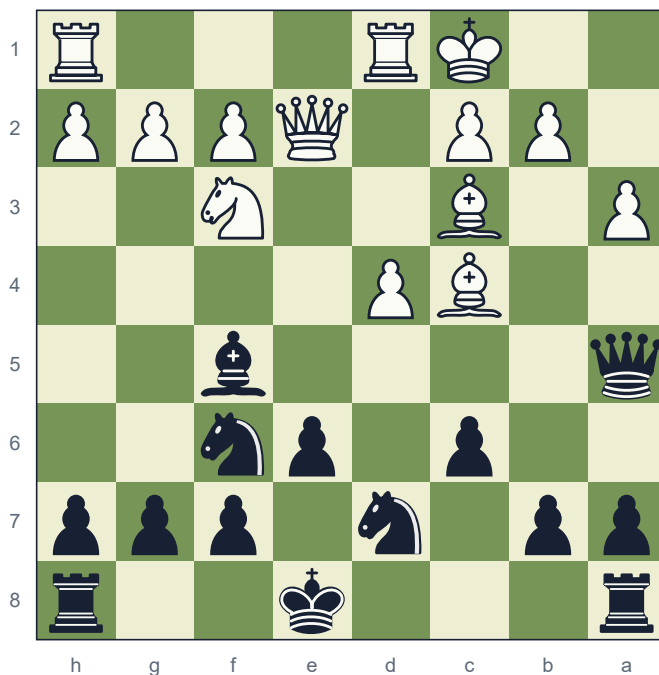
18... O-O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qc7 and Qd8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QC7

11... Qc7 12. Ne5 Nxe5 13. dxe5 Nd5 14. g4 Bg6 15. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.60 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QD8

11... Qd8 Search estimate: -0.86 from Black's perspective.

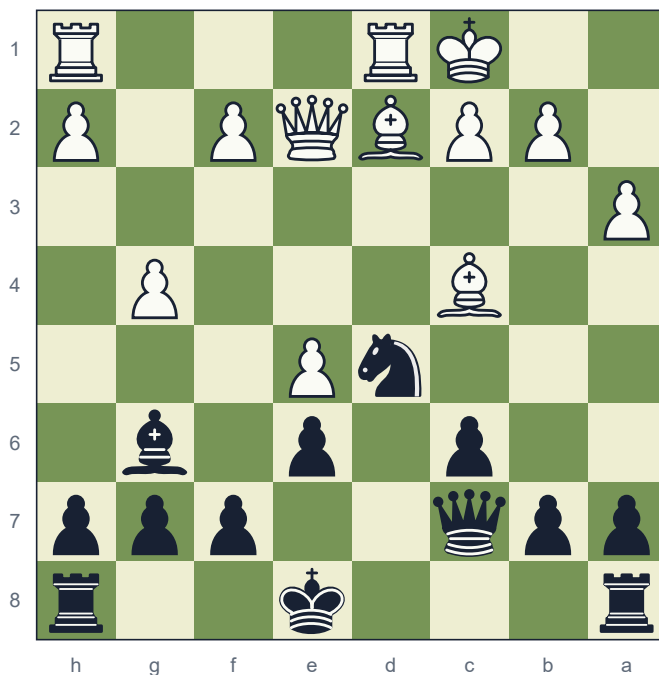
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

h5 and O-O-O. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE H5

15... h5 16. h3 O-O-O 17. f4 hxg4 18. hxg4 Rxh1 19. Rxh1 Search estimate: -0.28 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE O-O-O

15... O-O-O Search estimate: -0.31 from Black's perspective.

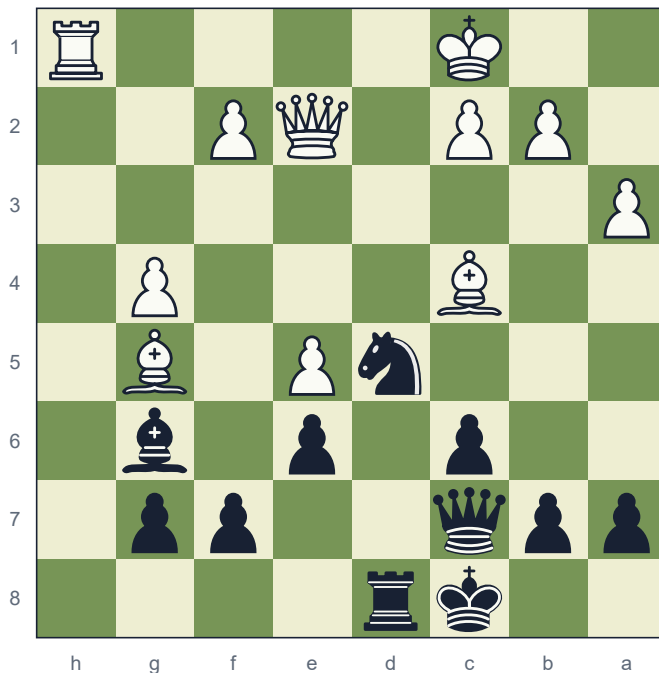
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Re8 and Rg8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king c8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RE8

19... Re8 20. Bb3 Search estimate: -0.33 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RG8

19... Rg8 20. f3 a6 21. Ba2 b5 22. f4 Re8 23. Rf1 Search estimate: -0.41 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on the e-file. It can support central pawns or pressure the opposing center after exchanges.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / White pushes g4 against the bishop



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

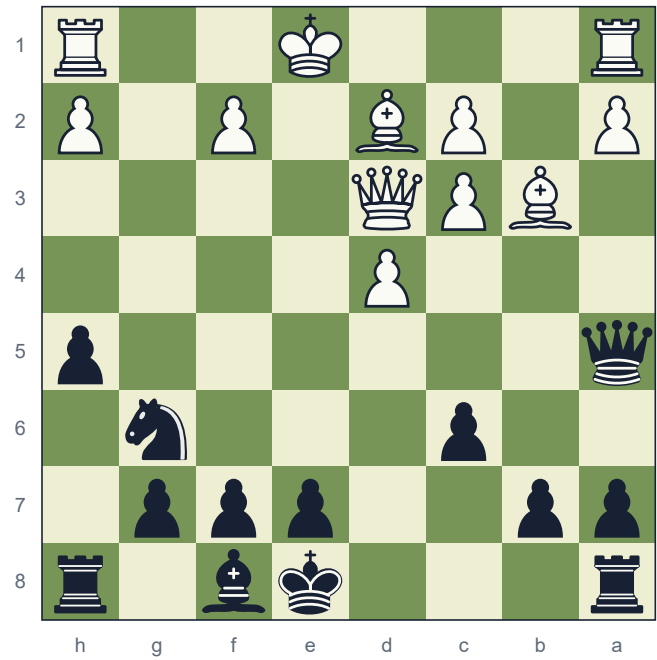
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-03 / play and explain 1

11... h5 12. g5 Nd5 13. Bd2 Nxc3 14. Qd3 Nh4 15. g6 Nxg6 16. bxc3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... H5

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

13... NXC3

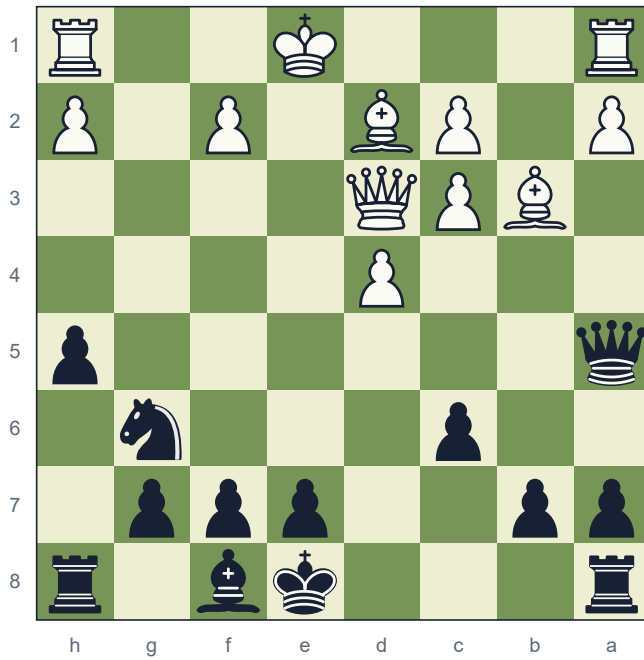
The knight captures a knight on c3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

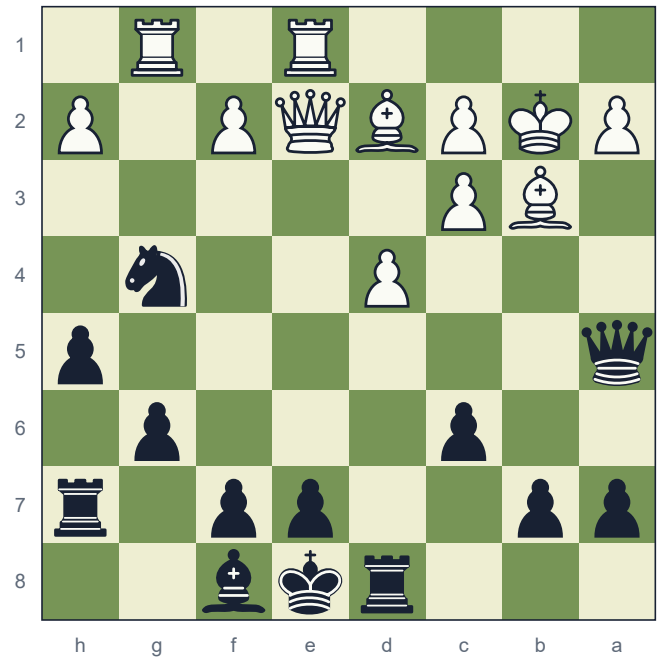
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-03 / play and explain 2

16... Rd8 17. Rg1 Ne5 18. Qe2 Ng4 19. O-O-O g6 20. Rde1 Rh7 21. Kb2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... RD8

Places the rook on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

18... NG4

Places the knight on g4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

h5 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE H5

11... h5 12. g5 Nd5 13. Bxd5 cxd5 14. O-O Nh4 15. g6 Search estimate: -0.26 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

11... e6 12. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

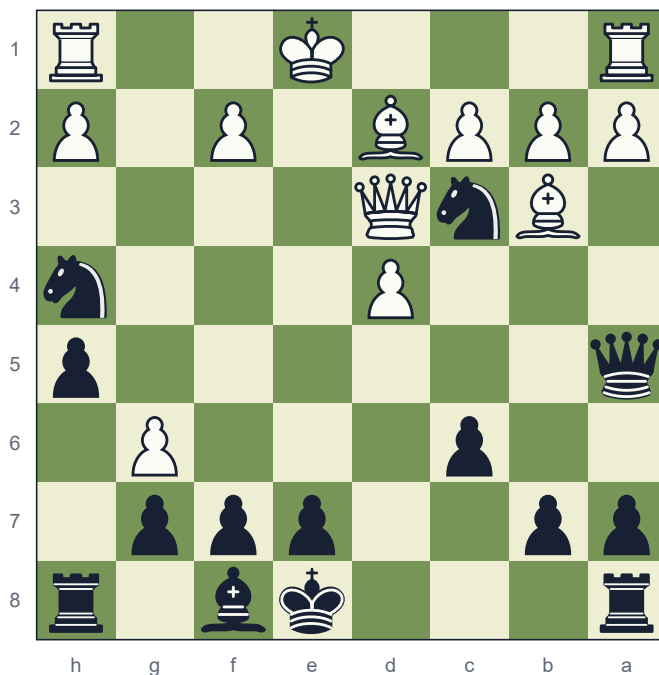
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxg6 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXG6

15... Nxg6 16. bxc3 Rd8 17. Rg1 Ne5 18. Qh3 Nd7 19. O-O-O Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

15... e6 16. Bxc3 Search estimate: -0.49 from Black's perspective.

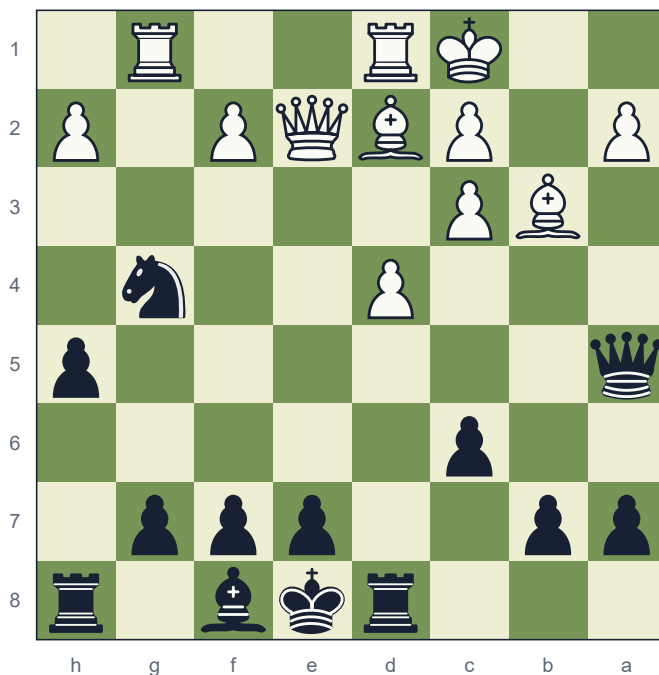
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a pawn on g6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

g6 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, c3, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE G6

19... g6 20. Rde1 Rh7 21. Kb2 Nh6 22. h3 Nf5 23. c4 Search estimate: +0.09 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

19... e6 20. Kb1 Qa6 21. Qf3 Nf6 22. Bg5 Be7 23. c4 Search estimate: +0.03 from Black's perspective.

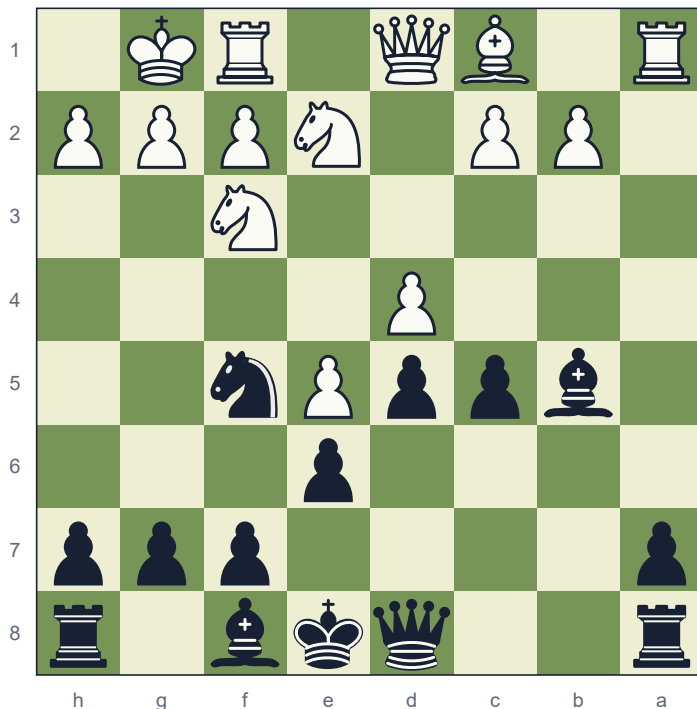
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / White advances with 2.e5



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

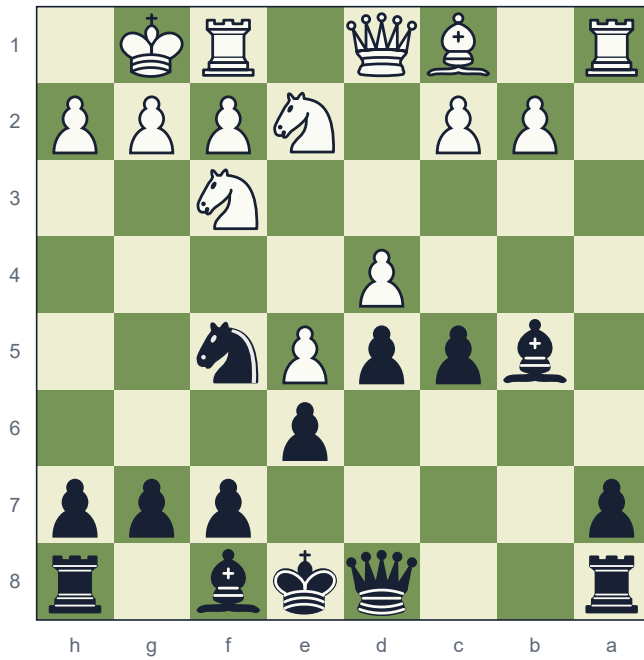
White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

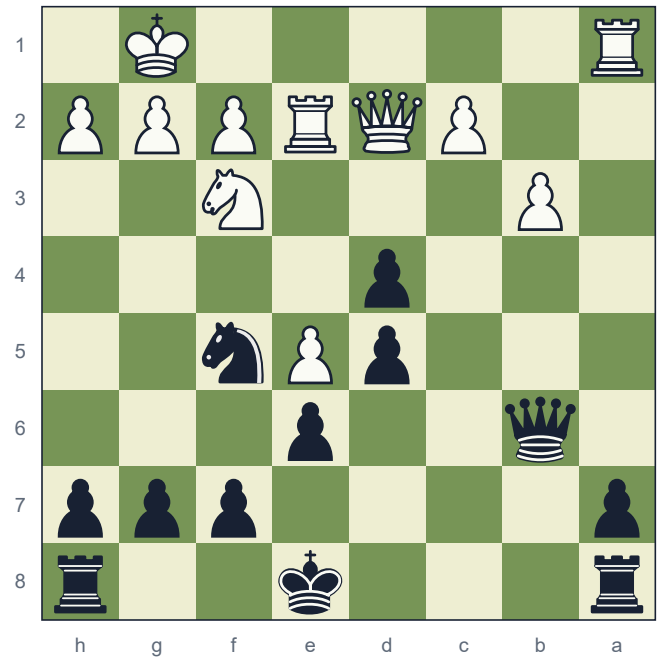
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-04 / play and explain 1

11... cxd4 12. Re1 Bb4 13. Bd2 Bxd2 14. Qxd2 Bxe2 15. Rxe2 Qb6 16. b3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... CXD4

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13... BXD2

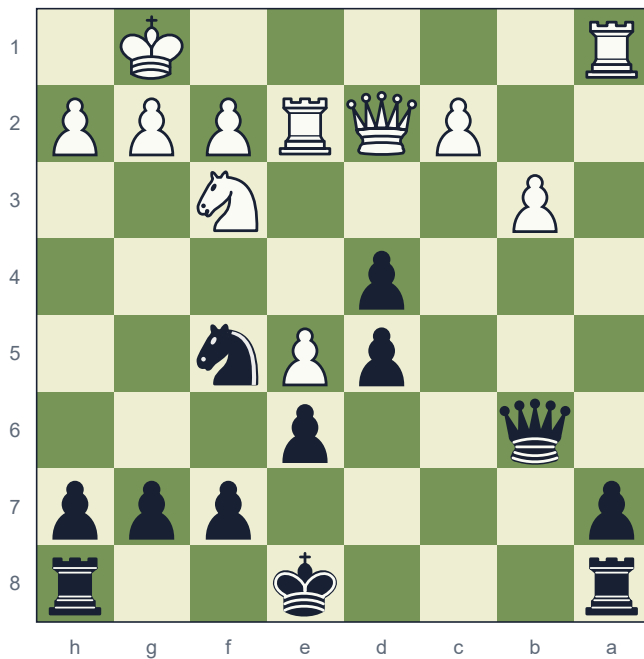
The bishop captures a bishop on d2. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

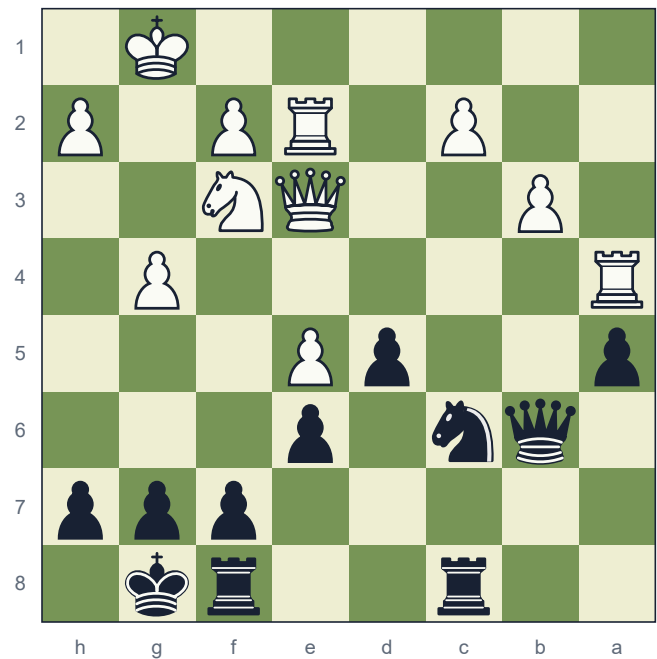
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-04 / play and explain 2

16... Rc8 17. Ra4 O-O 18. g4 Ne7 19. Nxd4 Nc6 20. Nf3 a5 21. Qe3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... Rc8

Places the rook on c8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

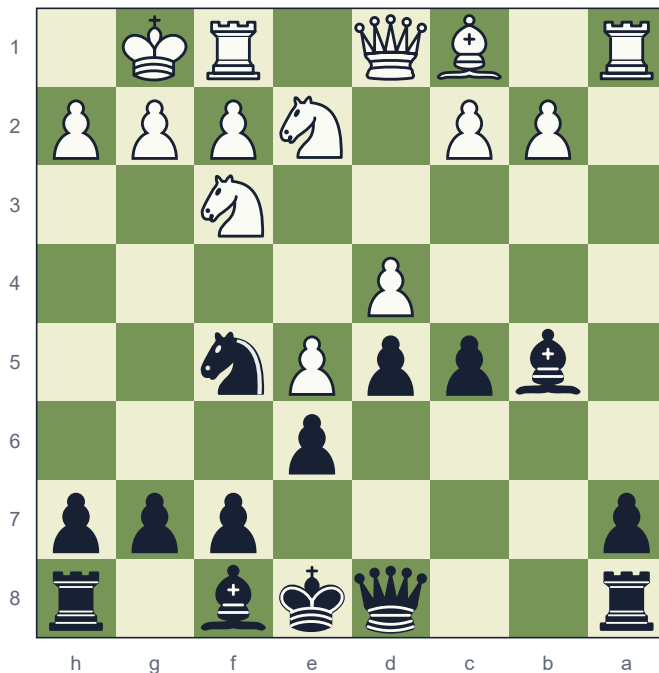
18... Ne7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

cx d4 and Be7. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE CXD4

11... cxd4 12. Re1 Bb4 13. Bd2 Bxe2 14. Rxe2 Bc5 15. Ba5 Search estimate: +0.40 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BE7

11... Be7 Search estimate: +0.20 from Black's perspective.

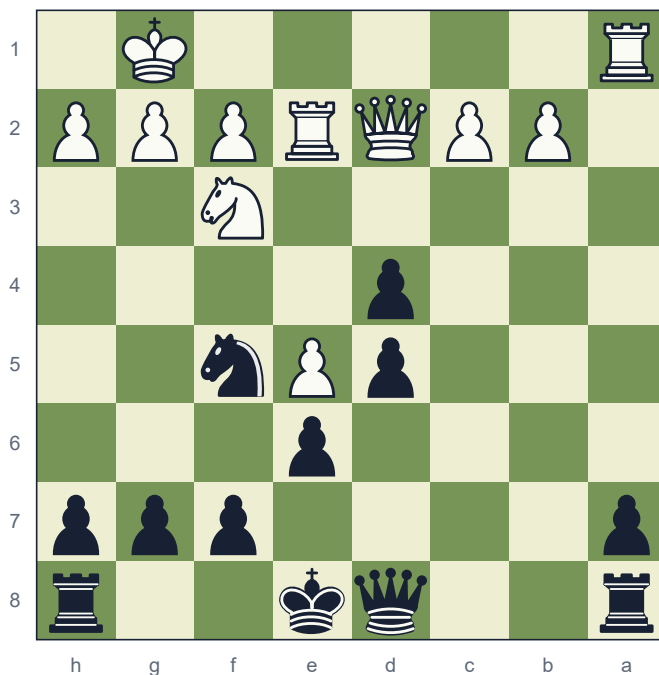
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qb6 and O-O. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d4, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QB6

15... Qb6 16. b3 Search estimate: +0.23 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE O-O

15... O-O 16. Nxd4 Search estimate: +0.23 from Black's perspective.

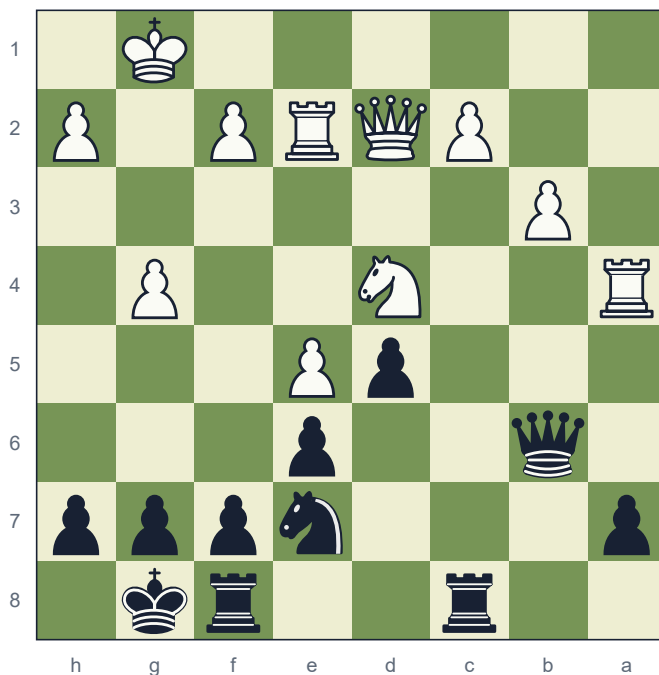
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on b6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nc6 and h6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NC6

19... Nc6 20. Nf3 a5 21. Qe3 Qxe3 22. Rxe3 h6 23. h4 Search estimate: +0.22 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE H6

19... h6 20. h4 Search estimate: +0.09 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on c6, attacking knight on d4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / White offers the Blackmar-Diemer



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White offers a pawn for development and open attacking lines. ...Bf5 develops before ...e6 and makes the extra material easier to defend.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

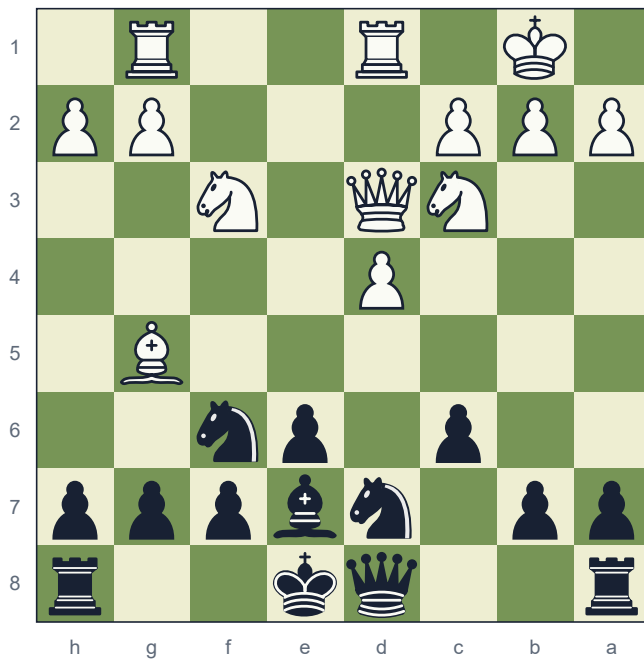
White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

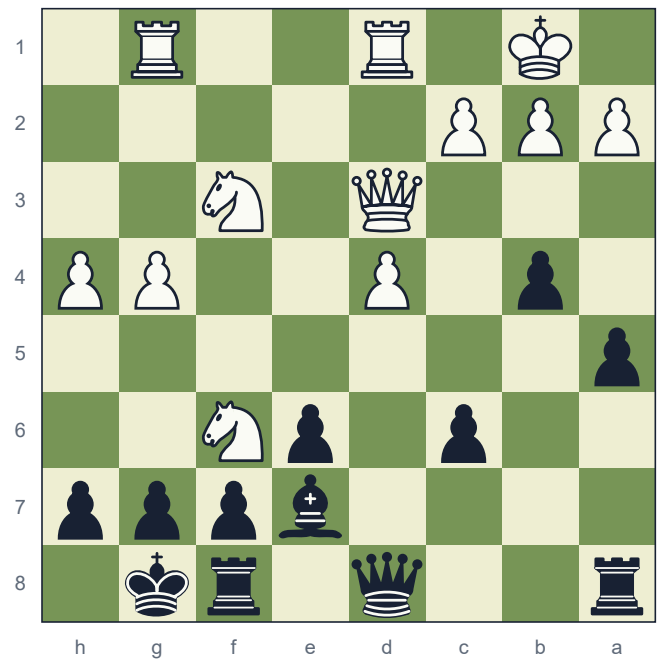
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-05 / play and explain 1

11... b5 12. g4 b4 13. Ne4 O-O 14. h4 a5 15. Bxf6 Nxf6 16. Nxf6+



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move - in check

11... B5

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... O-O

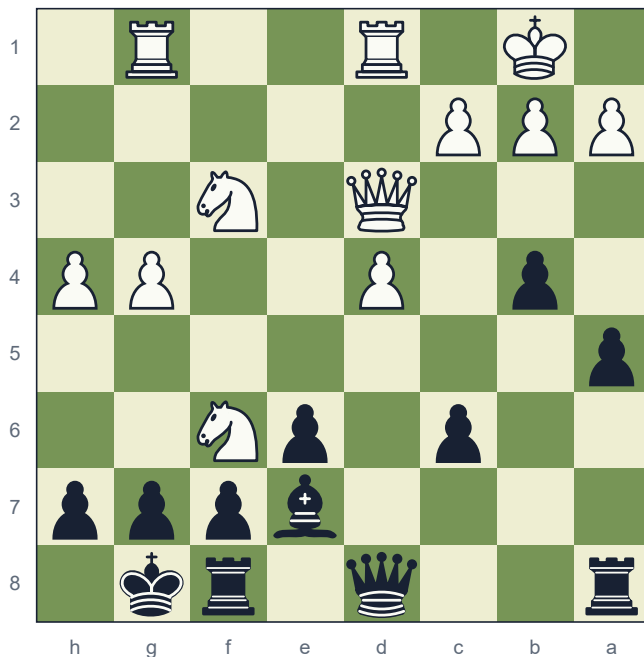
Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

REASSESS

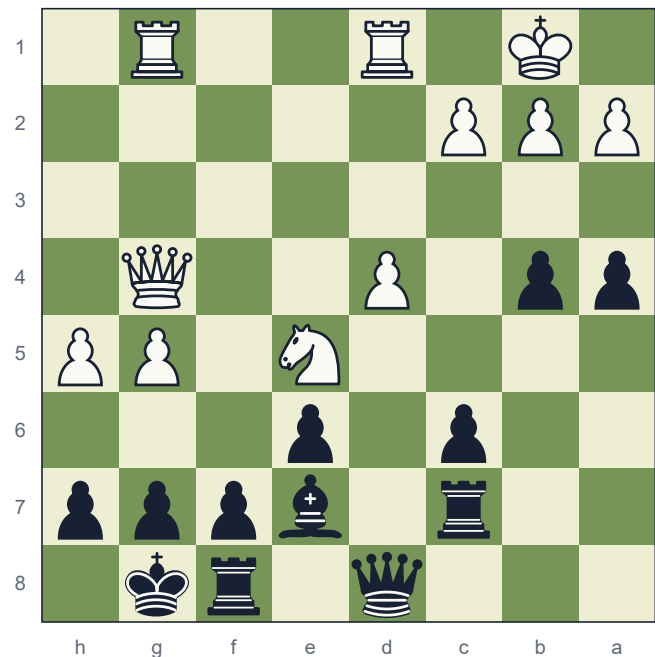
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-05 / play and explain 2

16... Bxf6 17. g5 Be7 18. Ne5 Rc8 19. Qe2 Rc7 20. Qg4 a4 21. h5



Before this segment - Black to move - in check



After this segment - Black to move

16... Bxf6

The bishop captures a knight on f6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

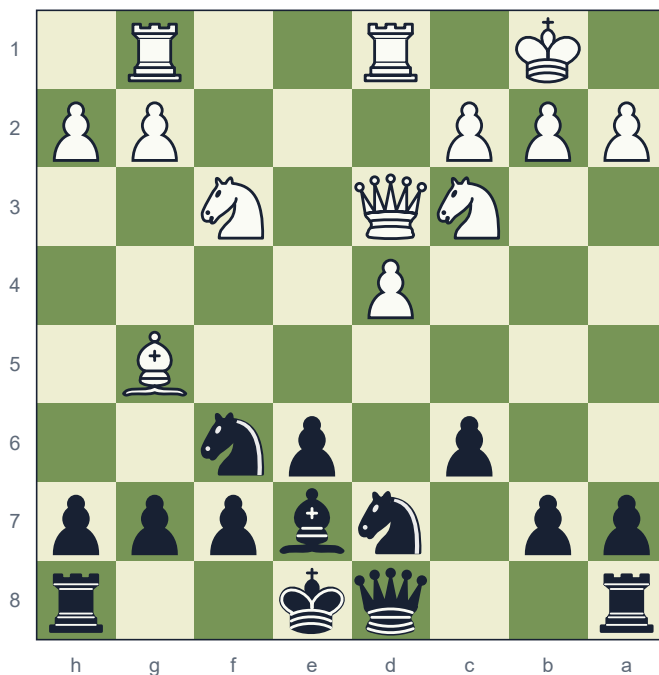
18... Rc8

Places the rook on c8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

b5 and Ng4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE B5

11... b5 Search estimate: +0.52 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NG4

11... Ng4 12. Bxe7 Qxe7 13. Rde1 O-O-O 14. a3 h6 15. Qe2 Search estimate: +0.34 from Black's perspective.

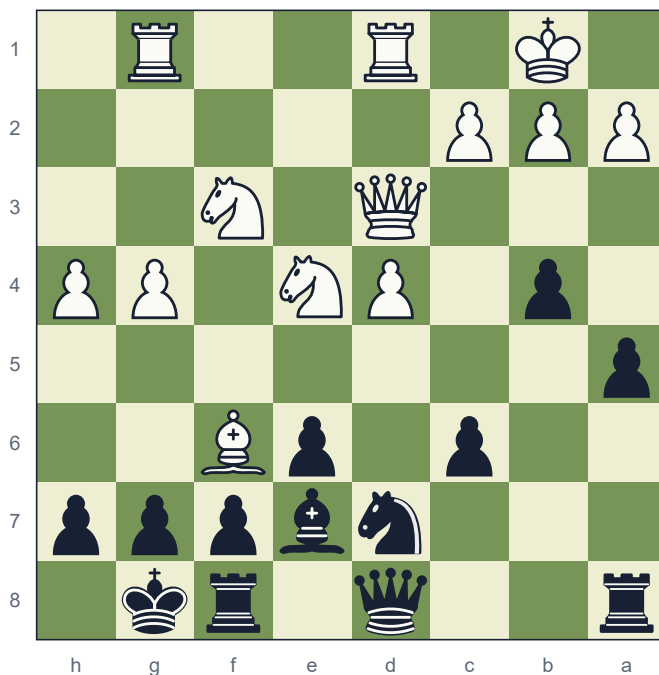
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxf6 and Bxf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXF6

15... Nxf6 16. Nxf6+ Bxf6 17. g5 Be7 18. Ne5 Rc8 19. Qe2 Search estimate: +0.57 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF6

15... Bxf6 16. g5 Search estimate: +0.08 from Black's perspective.

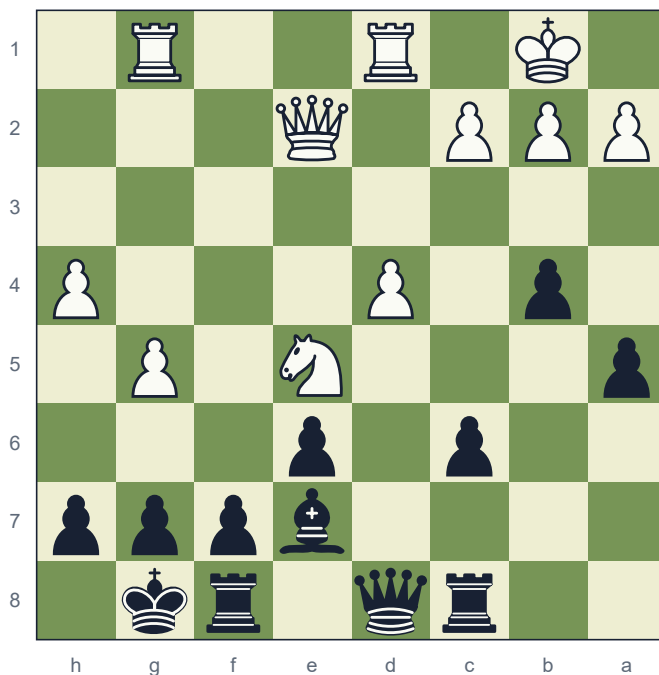
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a bishop on f6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rc7 and a4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RC7

19... Rc7 Search estimate: +0.72 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE A4

19... a4 20. Qa6 a3 21. Nxc6 Qd7 22. Nxe7+ Qxe7 23. h5 Search estimate: +0.46 from Black's perspective.

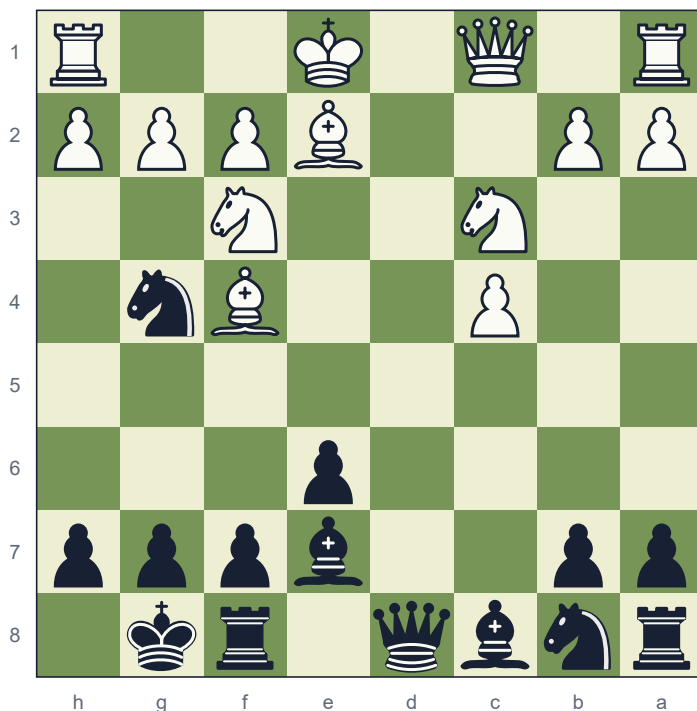
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / White attacks the queen with 3.c4



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

The c-pawn move gains a queen tempo but leaves d4 as a possible long-term target. Black retreats safely and develops.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

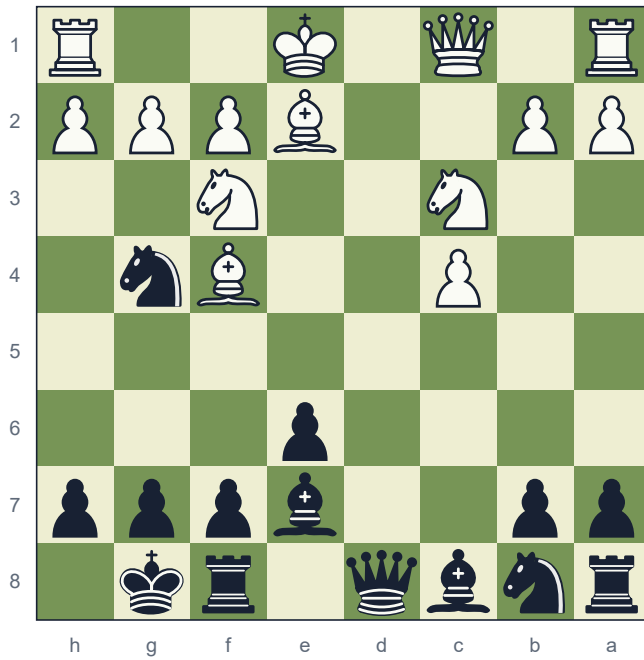
White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

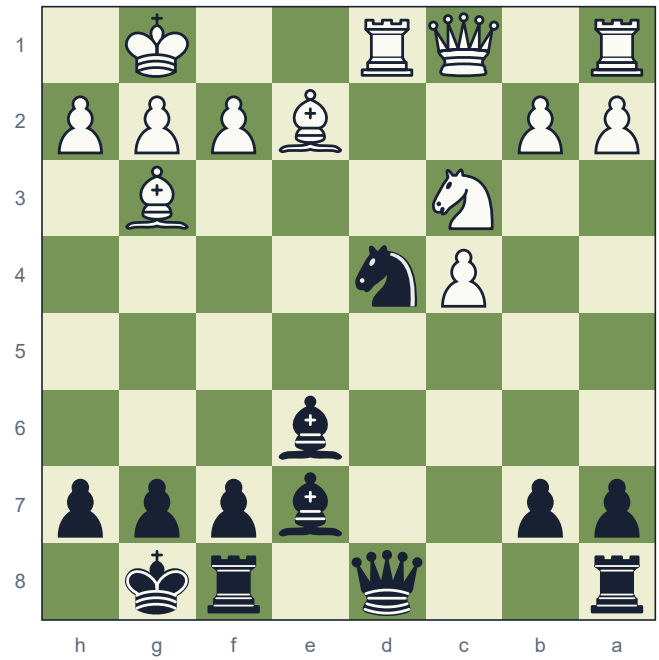
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-06 / play and explain 1

11... e5 12. Nxe5 Nxe5 13. Bxe5 Nc6 14. Bg3 Nd4 15. O-O Be6 16. Rd1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

13... NC6

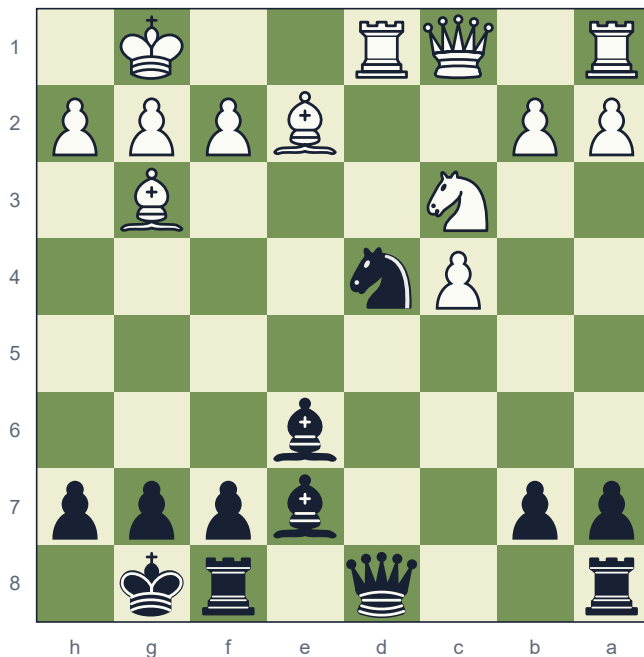
Places the knight on c6, attacking bishop on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

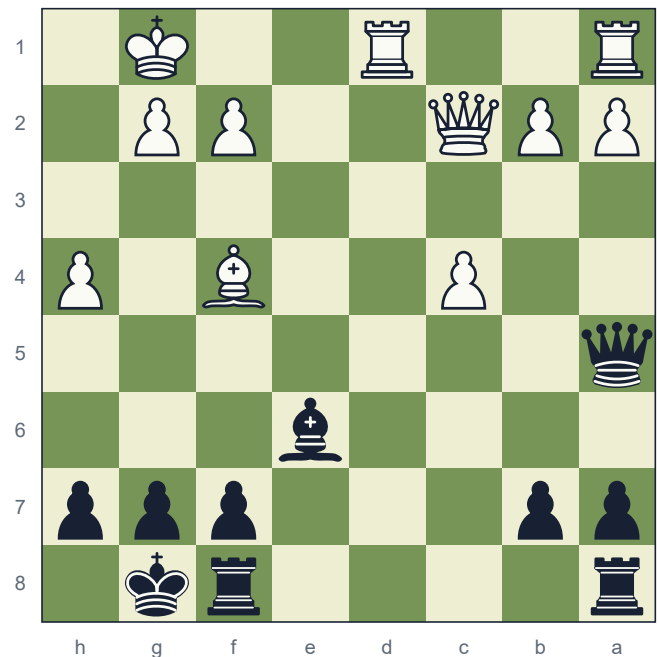
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-06 / play and explain 2

16... Nxe2+ 17. Nxe2 Qa5 18. Nf4 Bg5 19. h4 Bh6 20. Qc2 Bxf4 21. Bxf4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... NXE2+

The knight captures a bishop on e2. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

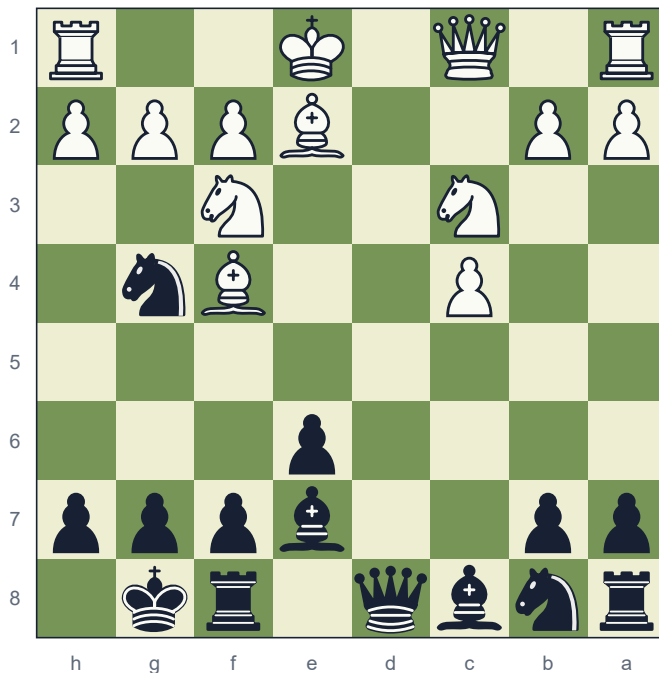
18... BG5

Places the bishop on g5, attacking knight on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

e5 and Nc6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE E5

11... e5 12. Nxe5 Nxe5 13. Bxe5 Nc6 14. Bg3 Bf6 15. O-O Search estimate: -0.59 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NC6

11... Nc6 Search estimate: -0.70 from Black's perspective.

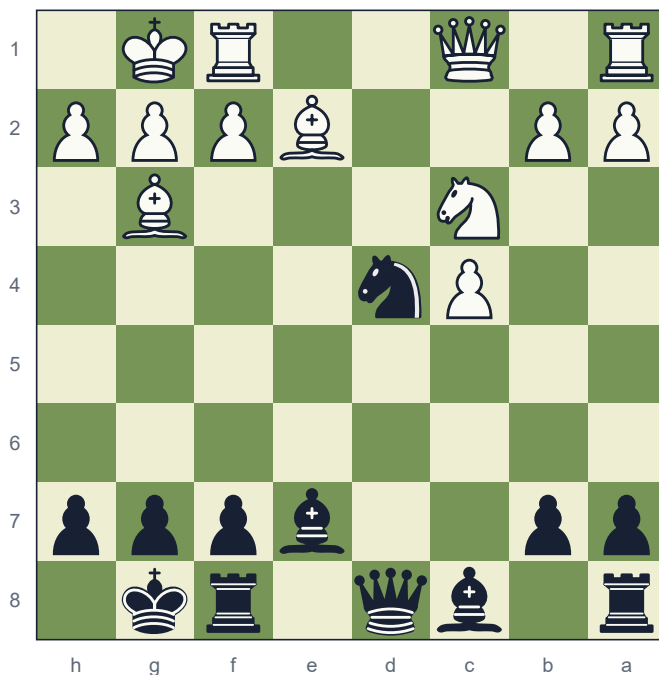
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Be6 and Bf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BE6

15... Be6 16. Rd1 Nxe2+ 17. Nxe2 Qb6 18. Nf4 Bg5 19. c5 Search estimate: -0.53 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BF6

15... Bf6 16. Bd1 Be6 17. Ne4 Be7 18. Be5 f6 19. Bxd4 Search estimate: -0.59 from Black's perspective.

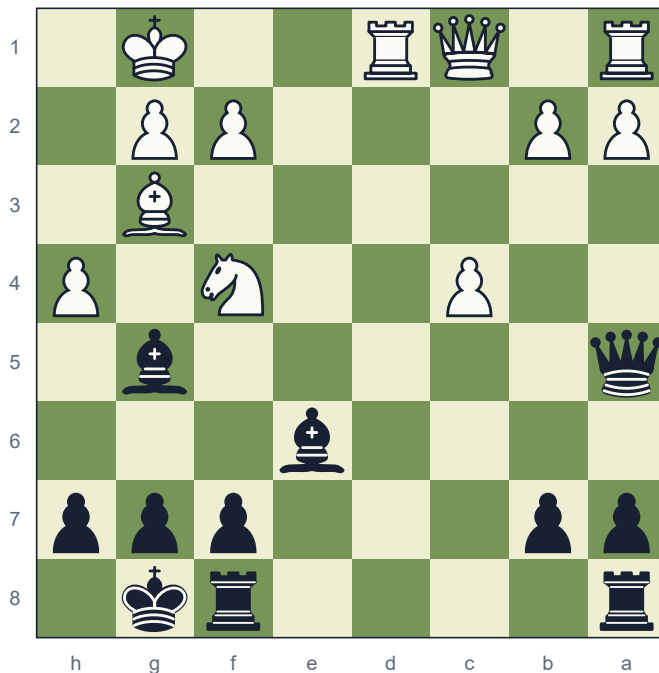
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on e6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bh6 and Bxf4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BH6

19... Bh6 20. Qc2 Bxf4 21. Bxf4 Rfd8 22. Qe4 Rxd1+ 23. Rxd1 Search estimate: -0.65 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF4

19... Bxf4 20. Bxf4 Search estimate: -0.75 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on h6, attacking knight on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.